

Syncretism in medieval Bengal

Political background under the Samanta chakra

- Pala- Sena periods after the establishment of dynastic rule in Bengal saw the rise of trade both internally and externally. The Aryan and South Indian clans who made up the *samanta chakra* –feudals- and their supporters were more into land holdings. The Varerndra based Samanta chakra linked to the Northern India ruling centre.
- Trading had participation of locals and as well people from outside Bengal.
- The emergence of Pala rulers through some form of consensus among the Samantas was intended to maintain a better social and political order. Prior to that political chaos in North India and foreign invaders had made samanta chakra life difficult.
- Palas were Aryans and Senas were from Karnataka in South India were the two clans who ruled Varendra as the centre and extended control over much of Samatat and other zones.
- The rebellion that overthrew Mahipala was mounted by some members of the chakra. Later Pala rule was installed by Rampala as mentioned in the Ramacharitam book which was commissioned by the Palas.
- This period saw conflict among the regional empires for the supremacy of North India centred in Kannauj. The Rastrakutas,, Gurjari-Pratiharas and the Palas were involved in the 9th century. The Palas held Kannauj for a short while but ultimately lost it.
- While the samanta chieftains and rulers were fighting, trade also grew. The Buddhist monasteries which also owned a great deal of land flourished under the Palas. Later however, the Senas went against them as they supported the Palas whom they replaced. It was a political not a religious decision.
- By the time Sena rule peaked, trade was high, generating an emerging class of powerful economic groups who were helped by the access to ports and the sea.

Arrival of Turko-Afghans

- When Bakhtiyar Khilji arrived, the trading community was strong and were challenging the samanta. Militarily, the Senas were not a major player in North India but trade wise they were regional and international.

· However, due to many changes including the ruling groups from another culture, we see the emergence of groups not mentioned in traditional literature, both economic and socio-cultural.

· **Three elements were noted. A. Rise of Vernacular literature such as the Mongol Kavya which shifted from oral narratives to the written form. B. Mention of non-Aryan deities such as Chandi and Manasa which were socially popular and rooted in the animist or nature-worshipping traditions. C. Rise of mixed socio-faith practices that was more socially accepted than ever before.**

· Such mixed faith practices are called syncretistic but this period saw a mix of many kinds not just faith. It was an era of mixing.

· Mongol Kavvyas had existed for long among ordinary people in oral forms but around this time 14th century became prominent as they emerged as texts. Some historians argue that their rise in the 14th century was a rallying cry of class and community alliance of locals against the invading Muslim Turko Afghans by putting various Hindu class cultural traditions closer in literature.

· The argument is that the poor and the low caste people did not resist the foreign invaders this was an attempt to bring all together. By incorporating lower class culture into the upper class texts was like producing an alliance by culture, making lower class culture respectable and holy.

· But this is very speculative as no such united revolt occurred and no such alliance is noted by contemporary historians. The lower class and caste were not literate so text being the basis of political alliance is not strong. Oral culture was more suited for mobilization of illiterate peasants.

· In 14th century Bengal, the demand for Mongol Kavya could only have come from those who were already familiar with such themes, and were ready to worship the earlier deities meaning from the non-Aryan traditions of the past.

· Possibly, worshippers of old non-Aryan deities had become socio-economically powerful enough to publicly patronize such cultures. As they were not landlords, then trade and commerce would be the source. Many of the literary characters were traders too like Chand Sawdagar.

· So the Turko Afghan invasion wasn't much of an interference with economic activities. The invaders would certainly gain from taxes paid by the traders. The rise of a well off class that was exerting some degree of social influence and power in society made united resistance less possible too with the older replaced samanta groups.

· The classical Aryan deity worshipping was not a matter that concerned the fishermen and farmers much as they had a large collection of deities going back in time and serving their survival needs. They were also from the lower castes so they would have less access to holy Brahmanical texts and ideas.

· However, the transformation of their gods as peers/ competitors of the older unquestioned Aryan deities led by Shiva shows that such ideas were gaining popularity portraying some social change. Mongol kavyas help in detecting new trends as we notice that in Manasamangal, the conflict is around the supremacy of deities, a conflict spot between Aryan and indigenous Hinduism which is however resolved. It means an inclusion of the marginal into the mainstream.

Behula +

The most famous Mongol Kavya is the Behula story which operates at several levels. 1. It shows Manasa, a local deity wanting to be treated at par with Shiva. She is very powerful and causes a lot of havoc including death of the Shiva devotee Chand Sowdagar.

But she ultimately compromises at the assembly of deities and accepts his left handed homage and restores Chand's family and wealth. This shows acceptance of powerful local deities due to social pressure and practice by the local landholding and literate class. But it also shows that the supremacy of the Aryan apex gods was established. It means both local and Vedic traditions were mixing.

2. These stories were mostly meant for public readings with a non-literate audience. Just listening to it was considered a holy ritual so listening itself was a ritual. It means widening the space for participation of local people of non-Aryan tradition but also accepting it. Its "syncretization" of several faith practices and streams at the social level.

3. What the Turko-Afghan rulers did was not to interfere with local practices. Nor did they convert people as it was a worthy deed. Now was conversion any part of their invasion objectives. However, they needed local support to rule comfortably so they did not do anything that would make local people more hostile.

4. Their focus may have been on the ousted ruling class and their supporters as they might mount a resistance. However, that didn't happen. Instead higher trade encouraged greater comfort with the new rulers by the locals particularly the trading community.

5. The Turko-Afghans were also worried about an invasion from Delhi whose overlordship they accepted first but later became independent under the Hossain Shahi, Iliyas Shahi, Sur, Karrani rule.. So gaining local support was an important strategy for survival for Turko-Afghans in Bengal. Supporting local culture was therefore a politically convenient move.

Syncretism dominates social history in Bengal. In a culture defined by mixed identities, the idea of any purity is unrealistic. However, historical narratives have been written by the ruling class who detested hybrid concepts. These ‘centrist’ groups mostly from North India or central Asia looked down upon deltaic people. They were not familiar with the culture and practices of syncretism that is inevitable in high migrant driven, agro-societies.

- ◆ In Bengal, we know that imperial culture- Mauryan, Gupta, later versions, etc never penetrated society which was more village clustered, in low level professions like agriculture and fishing and had a long history of life under animist belief structures. Thus the foundational basis of such people was always based on many ideas which were socially developed rather than theologically. This made mixing easy as social ideas are more flexible.
- ◆ Thus when Hinduism/ Buddhism arrived, they took on the more “popular” versions. People took what was acceptable and accessible to them. So it was not Vedic Hinduism that took root but a more popular – type mixing ancient myths with Vedic deities. Mongol Kabbya is a good example of this mix as society changed.
- ◆ Buddhism was even more obvious as the most esoteric, non-theologically derived version, Tantric Buddhism was popular here. Such faith practices were not about any philosophy but survival so whatever was useful for survival was adopted not what was theologically considered pure by the ruling class/ priestly class.
- ◆ Thus syncretism is a natural part of the Bengal deltaic faith life. At the social level its part of their natural life where establishing theological supremacy is not important as it’s not necessary given their ‘non-political’ life. So exchange and support, inter-mingling and borrowing is common. Usually the rulers insist on the supremacy of one faith which the ordinary people adopt and adjust to but the faith practices of the rulers and the ruled have differed much.
- ◆ Under Turko-Afghan rule in general and Sultani rule in particular, we see the rise of official promotion of mixing. Thus the Baul, Shahjiya, etc versions appear in society which is not mentioned in ruling class texts. The TA rulers had a practical reason to support syncretism and promote religious tolerance. As they were outsiders and in conflict with Delhi which would regularly invade, they needed local support for survival. Hence they were pushed by practical reasons to support such mixes. While Central Asian Islam was less rigid than Arabian Islam, the Hussain Shahi rulers who were of Arab descent also promoted heterodoxy. The Muslim rulers are not converting themselves into such faith so they were not threatened by such promotions. It was the faith practices of the same “Asura” or less civilized beings.
- ◆ The Turko-Afghans never converted anyone and that was not their objective. Their focus was on military conquest and taxation which continued till the end of their rule and Mughal

take over. They preached to themselves and not to the locals. The locals adopted some ideas as they always did from the rulers but no major social transition took place. Thus Islam was the religion of the rulers but not of the people, a matter that began to change when Mughals took over.

- ◆ Due to tectonic changes, eastward shift of the delta and river course changes increased the agro-potential of the Bengal basin. Land clearing and cultivation organizing contracts were issued to agro-entrepreneurs, tax for land rights by the Mughal state. Advantage went to “charismatic pioneers”, people with a reputation as religious and powerful. “They would enlist followers to build a shrine, a requirement under the state grant, and settle people around it. This group -built around a shrine was called – shomaj who were migrants from Northern and Western Bengal- which was less fertile by then, would clear the field and plant rice. Locals of shifting cultivation would either join or go deep into the forests and maintain contact with these settled agriculturists.
- ◆ Many charismatic were Hindus but most were Muslims, and many were called pirs. Thus Islam, agriculture, state supported settle agriculture became one ‘ideology’. Thus ancient Bengali animist + Hindu-Buddhist rituals along with Mosque and shrine culture blended into what we call Bengali version of Islam. It was syncretism at work.
- ◆ Thus over time, all elements came together to produce, myths, legends, personifications and respect for the “Islamic superhuman” who were also miracle agricultural workers.
- ◆ Thus social syncretism has always existed and occasionally the rulers have ignited the process with the ruled for their own needs.

Summation

Thus there were several “syncretisms” at work.

- a. . Mixing and adjusting faith tradition was on in Bengal for a long time and served various purposes. In this phase, the background was the loss of ruling supremacy by the North Indian rulers to Turko-Afghan invaders.
- b. The invading ruling class was interested in promoting local culture to strengthen their foreign rule. Later, as Bengal Turko-Afghans became independent they supported local culture even more to develop a barricade against possible invasion by imperial Delhi Sultans.
- c. This period coincided with the emergence of a local /non-local trading community and their interest in mixing local and Aryan deities. The trading community and related upper class who were more rooted in indigenous cultural traditions promoted this culture.

d. They produced texts and supported earlier pre- Aryan traditions as they were also part of that stream. They had the opportunity and interest to do so as it strengthened their position.

e. Traditional Vedic Hinduism of the elite mixed with animist beliefs of the locals to produce a syncretistic narrative literature like the Kavyas. Non-literate peasant ideas and aspirations were acceptable to trading class ambitions and search for status.

f. . All these elements came together to produce a period of seeking mutual support through the mix and engagement of faith and cultural traditions.